

THE WINGED HORSE

Pegasus



SIZE RANKING 7

BRIGHTEST STARS

Beta (β) 2.4,
Epsilon (ε) 2.4

GENITIVE Pegasi

ABBREVIATION Peg

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
September–October

FULLY VISIBLE
90°N–53°S



Pegasus lies north of the zodiacal constellations Aquarius and Pisces, in low northern declinations, and it adjoins Andromeda. It was one of the original 48 Greek constellations. Pegasus represents the flying horse ridden by the hero Bellerophon, although he is sometimes wrongly identified as the steed of Perseus (see panel, below). Although only the forequarters of the horse are indicated by stars, the constellation is still the seventh-largest in the sky.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The Great Square of Pegasus is formed by the stars Alpha (α), Beta (β), and Gamma (γ) Pegasi, plus Alpha (α) Andromedae. Long ago, the fourth star of the Square was also known as Delta (δ) Pegasi and was shared with



THE GREAT SQUARE

The most distinctive feature of this constellation is the Great Square of Pegasus, which forms the horse's body.



Andromeda, but now it is exclusively Andromeda's. A line of more than 30 full moons would fit into the Square, yet for such a large area it is surprisingly devoid of stars, its brightest one being Upsilon (υ) Pegasi, of magnitude 4.4. Therefore, when the Great Square is viewed through polluted skies, it may seem completely empty.

The constellation's two brightest stars are Beta, a red giant that varies between magnitudes 2.3 and 2.7, and Epsilon (ε) Pegasi, a yellow star of magnitude 2.4 with a wide 8th-magnitude companion that can be seen through a small telescope.

Not far from Epsilon lies the globular cluster M15 (see p.295), which is one of the finest such objects in northern skies. It is just at the limit of naked-eye visibility when viewed through clear skies.

Just outside the Great Square of Pegasus is a 5th-magnitude star called 51 Pegasi, which was the first star beyond the Sun confirmed to have a planet in orbit around it. This planet was discovered in 1995, and its mass is about half that of Jupiter.

MYTHS AND STORIES

BELLEROPHON AND PEGASUS

Pegasus the winged horse was born from the body of Medusa, the Gorgon, when she was decapitated by Perseus. He flew to Mount Helicon, home of the Muses, where he stamped on the ground and brought forth a spring called Hippocrene, the "horse's fountain." With the aid of a golden bridle from Athena, the hero Bellerophon tamed Pegasus, and rode the horse on his successful mission to kill the fire-breathing monster Chimera. Bellerophon later attempted to ride Pegasus up to Olympus to join the gods, but he fell off. The horse arrived safely.

TAKING FLIGHT

Pegasus beats his wings, as though attempting to ascend to the skies, in this statue in Powerscourt Gardens, Dublin, Ireland.



M15

A telescope with 6-in (150-mm) aperture resolves this cluster into individual stars. It is over 30,000 light-years away.



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